cavalry, Monserrate noted that ‘the Mongols, Persians, Parthians, Turks, Sogdians, Bachtrae and Scythians all use the same fighting tactics’. They were ‘most dangerous when they seem to be flying in headlong riot for, turning round on their horses, although they are going at full gallop, they fling their javelins with such deadly aim that they can transfix the eye of an enemy’. These elite horsemen fought as light cavalry, galloping while standing almost upright in their stirrups. The Rajputs meanwhile were employed as heavy cavalry, fighting hand to hand with lance and swords while firmly seated in the saddle, legs fully extended.

While the mansabdars were sheathed in gleaming armour, the regular cavalrymen had to content themselves with long quilted coats to absorb the impact of swords and arrows. On the lower body, they wore cotton trousers tied with a shawl and folds of quilted cloth to protect their heads in lieu of helmets. Raja Man Singh, Madhu Singh, Surat Singh, and other elite noblemen threw themselves into the attack and this was when Mirza Hakim sent the offer to Akbar’s soldiers, claiming that ‘the Turanis and Persians… will join us without fighting and the brave Rajputs and gallant Afghans will end their days…’ Abu’l Fazl was greatly scornful of this tactic, saying that ‘the great deeds of the Rajputs and the Shaikh-zadas of India [were] unknown to [Mirza Hakim]’. The men disdained Mirza Hakim’s call and his army was soon routed and Mirza Hakim fled the scene of battle.

After first sending heralds to announce to the ‘merchants, workmen, and common people’ that they need not fear any reprisals, Akbar marched into Kabul where he had spent his boyhood in the shade of the chinar trees and the riotous company of his milk brothers.

While in Kabul, Akbar attended to two particularly galling derelictions of duty in his officers. The paymaster, who had been sent ahead of Akbar’s party with 15,000 pieces of gold coins to pay Mirza Murad’s troops’ salaries, had been ambushed and captured by Mirza Hakim’s men. Despite having enough men to put up a determined resistance, he had allowed himself to be shamefully captured without inflicting or receiving a single cut or wound. For this the Padshah ‘upbraided him soundly for his carelessness and cowardice’. Even more embarrassing was the routing of Shaikh Jamal Bakhtiyar, a brother-in-law of the Padshah’s, who had also been ambushed and put to flight. So terrified was the man at the reaction of the Padshah that he ‘adopted the scanty clothing, bare head and unshod feet of a dervish’, preferring a life of banishment to the utter humiliation of